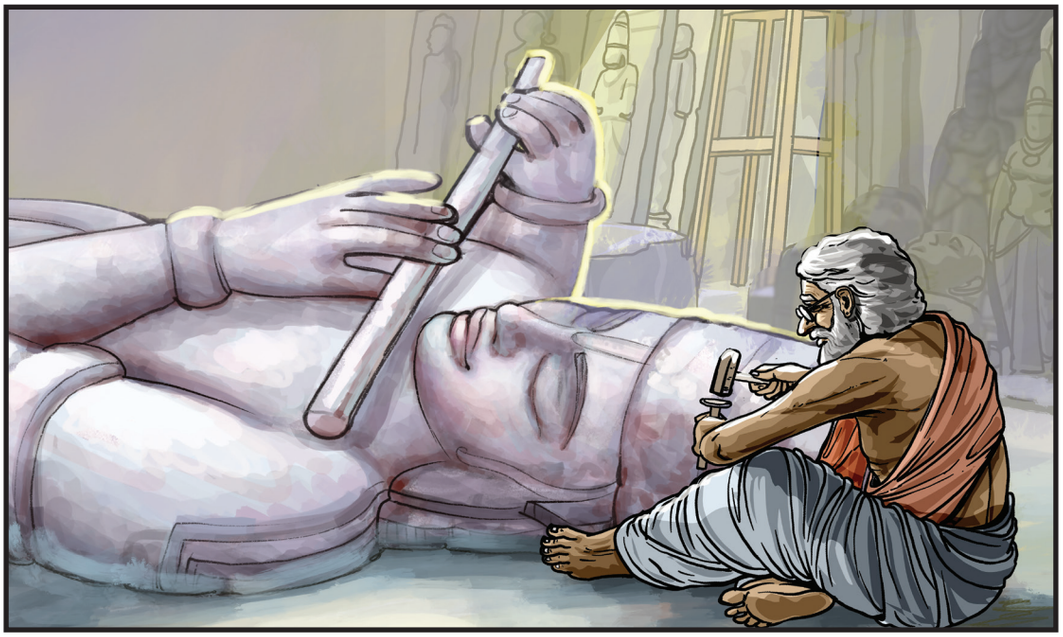
Section II



Days and weeks went by. It was a month since Gopal had left. The old man worked tirelessly. It was all there, in the stone the strong, straight shoulders of Krishna, his soft curved hips, the pointed fingers holding the flute delicately to his lips, his **serene** face eternally beautiful – the old man could see it in the stone. He could feel it. He only had to set it free with the chisel.

He didn't feel hunger, he didn't feel thirst. He was driven by the strong desire to finish the sculpture in time. It was his biggest piece of work, his best. It would also be his last.

On and on he worked, his chisel striking the stone again and again. But then came the day when the old man felt his strength ebb. His shoulders began to ache, his arms felt heavy and his vision **blurred**. Overcome with fear, he sank to his knees and prayed. The old man prayed a lot these days.

"Masterjee," Salim said, "You haven't touched your food again. Please have some rice and vegetables. You only had a glass of milk for breakfast. Have the curd. You like curd, I know you do."

The old man looked up. He whispered, "I don't think I'll be able to finish it. If Gopal was here, it would be different. He hadn't yet learnt to carve the finer details but in a year or two he would have learnt surely."

He felt silent. "It was the features and hands that gave him trouble. There was something missing in his figures. That something which can't be taught."

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